

Cultures as Catalysts: Nurturing HCI Communities Across Regions

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Abstract

This Meet-Up explores how *regional cultural values* can act as a catalyst for the growth and sustainability of HCI communities and research agendas worldwide. Organized by the chairs of SIGCHI Regional Committees (Asia CHI, Latin America CHI, Mediterranean CHI), with support from the SIGCHI VP at Large, the session positions Regional Committees as *bridges* that attract new participants, mentor and nurture local ecosystems, and connect bottom-up initiatives to the global CHI network. Through short framings, small-group dialogues, and collective synthesis, we will surface culture-aware practices for attraction, mentoring and opportunities for culturally grounded community-building and collaboration. The session aims to produce a concise set of reusable outputs (1) better *attract and welcome* newcomers and underrepresented groups; (2) *nurture* local communities via context-sensitive programming; and (3) translate regional insights into *globally visible* collaborations within SIGCHI.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Human computer interaction (HCI)**; *Collaborative and social computing*.

Keywords

HCI communities, culture, inclusivity, regional capacity building, SIGCHI Regional Committees, bottom-up participation, culture-aware practices, mentorship, multilingual access, cross-regional collaboration

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1 Introduction

Promoted by the chairs and members of Asia CHI, Latin America CHI, and Mediterranean CHI Regional Committees, together with the SIGCHI VP at Large for regions, this Meet-Up aims to explore how regional cultural values can catalyze the growth and long-term sustainability of HCI communities worldwide. The session positions SIGCHI Regional Committees as cultural bridges capable of attracting newcomers, mentoring emerging researchers, and connecting local initiatives to the global HCI network.

This discussion is timely and relevant: although HCI is a global discipline, research priorities, community practices, and participation barriers remain deeply shaped by regional contexts and local cultural values. Even in the most active regions, countries are represented unevenly [1]. As SIGCHI celebrates the rich diversity across its events and initiatives, it also recognizes the value of highlighting the common ground that exists amid these differences [3]. Cultural values, e.g., community solidarity, linguistic diversity, cultural heritage, or local traditions, indeed shape how people learn, collaborate, and mobilize around HCI topics.

SIGCHI Regional Committees have emerged as strategic intermediaries that *translate* and *mediate* between global and local levels: with their activities, they identify region-specific needs, convene stakeholders, attract new participants, and nurture local communities through culturally grounded initiatives and activities. Despite this invaluable work, the efforts of Regional Committees often remain siloed and underrecognized within the broader global HCI community. This lack of visibility and awareness limits opportunities for cross-regional learning, resource sharing, and coordinated action among the broader HCI community. Valuable lessons, successful strategies, and innovative approaches developed in one region may not reach others who could benefit from them. The absence of structured channels for inter-regional communication also makes it difficult to build a cohesive and inclusive global HCI network.

Bringing together representatives from different Regional Committees and global communities, this Meet-Up thus will address



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a twofold gap: first, regional cultural strengths are often underleveraged in the design of engagement, mentorship, and programming within the global HCI community [2]; second, bottom-up ideas from local communities are not always consistently captured to inform SIGCHI's global agenda. The session offers a dedicated forum at CHI 2026 to discuss these gaps and (i) identify *field-informed, culture-aware* practices through which Regional Committees can attract, include, and engage; (ii) sustain diverse HCI constituencies; (iii) package these practices into concise, reusable outputs for future community-building efforts.

2 Objectives and Activities

These Meet-Up is designed as a highly interactive and inclusive space for discussing how cultural values shape HCI research, participation, and community-building across regions. The session combines structured facilitation, small-group dialogue, and collective synthesis to foster shared understanding and seed future collaborations. Participatory methods will ensure equitable engagement across linguistic and cultural backgrounds. All outputs will be documented and shared openly after the conference.

Participants will first be welcomed with a brief introduction to the Regional Committees' mission and the session's goals, followed by an icebreaker in which they contribute keywords that capture what "culture" means in their HCI practice. This shared grounding will prepare for a brief framing moment, where representatives from MedCHI, AsiaCHI, and Latin America CHI highlight examples of culturally grounded initiatives that have helped attract newcomers and nurture local HCI communities in their regions.

The core of the Meet-Up consists of small-group dialogues. Mixed tables will discuss, guided by prompts emphasizing experience diversity and regional commonalities and specificities, such as:

- (1) How do cultural contexts shape HCI research and practices?
- (2) Which cultural values in your region help (or hinder) recruiting and welcoming newcomers?
- (3) What local mentoring/capacity-building formats have worked, and why?
- (4) What support or infrastructures are missing from Regional Committees?

After the group discussions, participants will reconvene for a collective synthesis. Each group will share a few key practices, needs, or challenges they identified. Facilitators will cluster these inputs into broader themes, such as recruitment, mentorship, accessibility and language, or cross-regional exchange, to build a shared landscape of priorities.

The session concludes with an open reflection on next steps. Chairs will summarize the main insights and actionable items, gather contact points, and outline a plan for continued collaboration. Participants will be invited to join a cross-regional working cluster aimed at sustaining momentum after the conference.

Overall, the Meet-Up aims to produce immediately reusable guidance for the Regional Committees, along the following dimensions:

- (1) **Attraction:** identify culture-informed strategies that lower entry barriers and attract newcomers (students, practitioners, and underrepresented groups) to HCI activities in each region.

- (2) **Nurturing:** Compile concrete, actionable mentoring and capacity building practices (cadence, matching, materials) that can sustain engagement in local communities, tailored to regional cultures and infrastructures.
- (3) **Bridging:** outline mechanisms to translate local initiatives' insights into cross-regional collaborations and globally visible contributions within the SIGCHI ecosystem (contact map, first milestones).

3 Communities of Interest

Our Meet-Up aims to bring together representatives from different Regional Committees and global communities, which could help foster mutual understanding, amplify localized successes, and lay the groundwork for more unified and collaborative future community-building initiatives. No prior familiarity with committee structures is required. A general interest in community building and cultural perspectives in HCI is sufficient. The session, therefore, appeals to:

- HCI researchers and practitioners who have already engaged with and/or are seeking to engage with global and regional community activities;
- HCI researchers and practitioners interested in inclusive, culturally grounded approaches to community building;
- Students and early-career scholars looking for mentorship and networking opportunities.

4 Expected Outcomes

By capturing bottom-up input, the Meet-Up will generate reusable outputs and actionable directions for strengthening Regional Committees' role in attracting, supporting, and nurturing diverse global HCI communities. The main expected outputs are:

- An openly-shared **practice sheet** summarizing strategies for attracting, supporting, and nurturing HCI communities tailored to regional cultures.
- A **bottom-up priorities list** informing Regional Committees' roadmap for, e.g., recruitment, mentorship, language support, funding micro-grants, cross-regional collaborations and exchanges, and other relevant aspects.
- A **cross-regional working cluster** to pilot shared initiatives, e.g., culture-informed mentoring series or seasonal schools.

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